Microsoft

GUIDE · NOVEMBER 2026

Microsoft deck guide

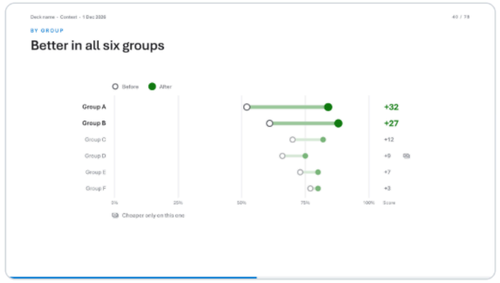
How to make slides in the Microsoft look, from a quick update to a big talk.

Federico Brancasi · Microsoft

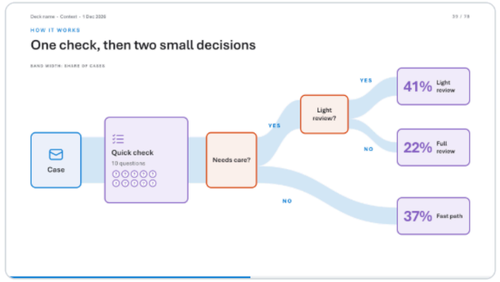
SIMPLE 1



GRAPHS 2



ILLUSTRATIONS 3



`guide-cover`

Microsoft deck guide

The guide shows slides instead of describing them. Every example is built with the kit, from neutral sample content.

CONTENTS

What is in this guide

01 **Foundations** 5
Frame, colour, type, do and don't

02 **Level 1: Simple** 11
Cards, big numbers, scorecards

03 **Level 2: Graphs** 13
Charts, tables, diagrams, builds

04 **Level 3: Illustrations** 18
Drawn objects and click-by-click pictures

05 **Writing and shapes** 29
Titles, deck outlines, the checks

`guide-contents`

What is in this guide

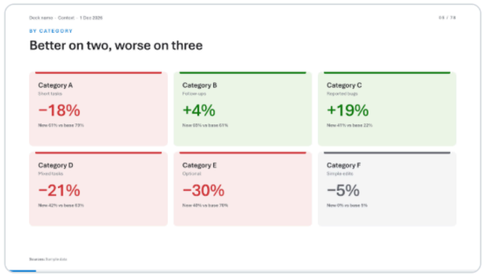
Read the first two pages, then jump to the level you need. The foundations apply to every level.

Microsoft deck guide 03 / 32

THREE LEVELS

One look, three levels of craft

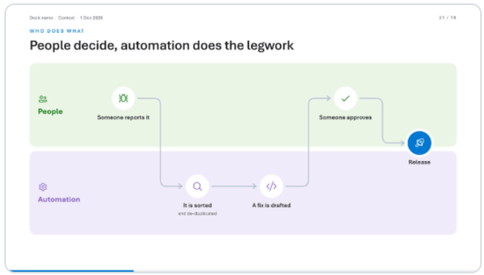
1 Simple



Updates and reviews: numbers and words carry it.

`cards scorecard bignumber breakdown versus takeaways`

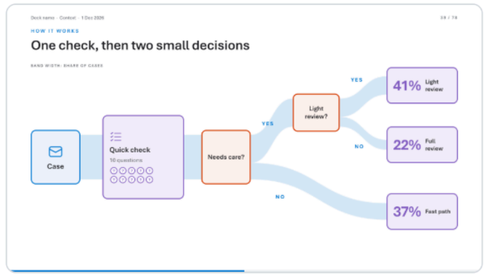
2 Graphs



Reports: a chart or a diagram carries it.

`bars funnel matrix flow pipeline lanes timeline cycle`

3 Illustrations



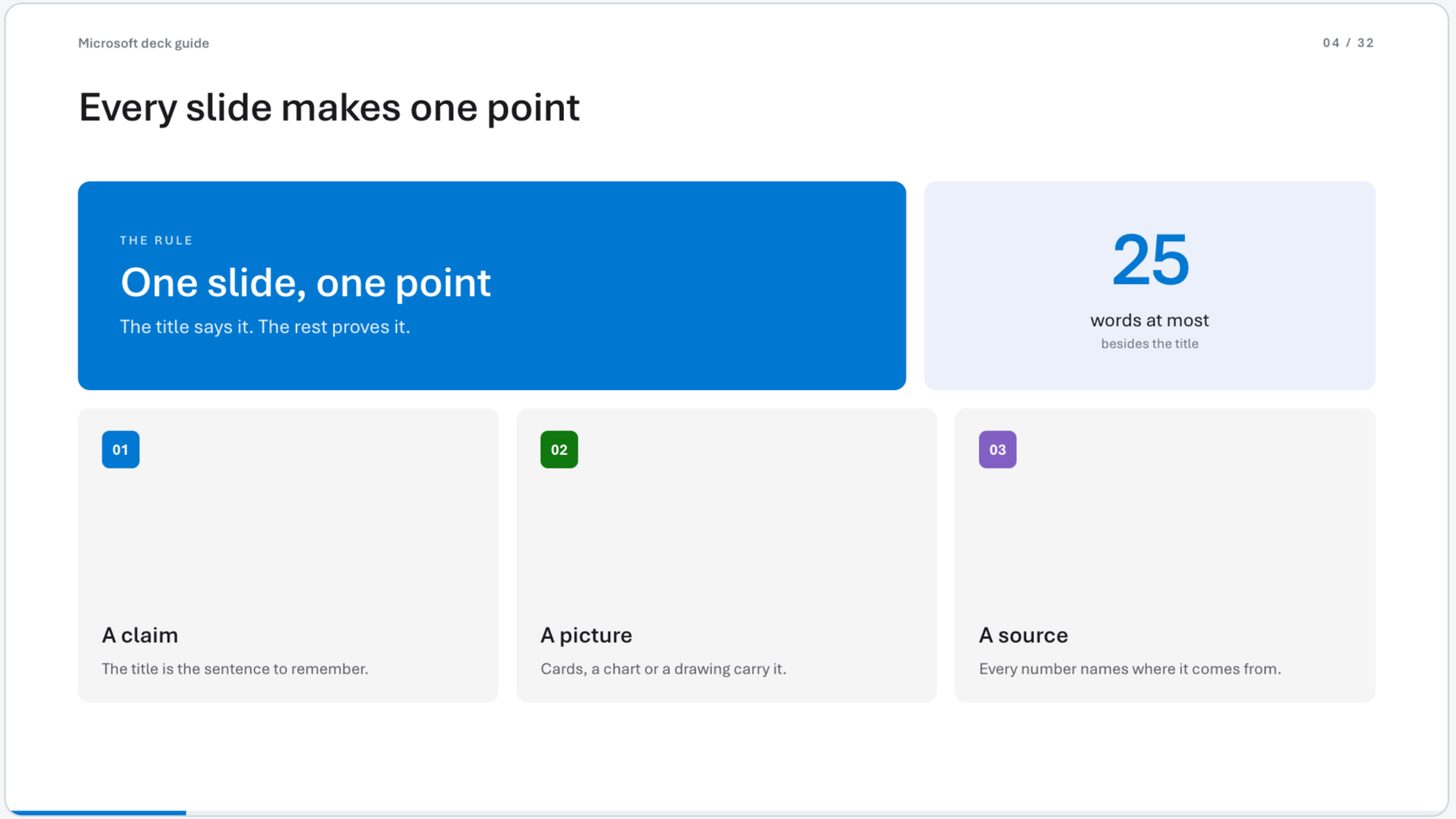
Big talks: a drawn object carries it.

`fork-cover sieve flow-bands dumbbell ladders launch`

`guide-levels`

One look, three levels of craft

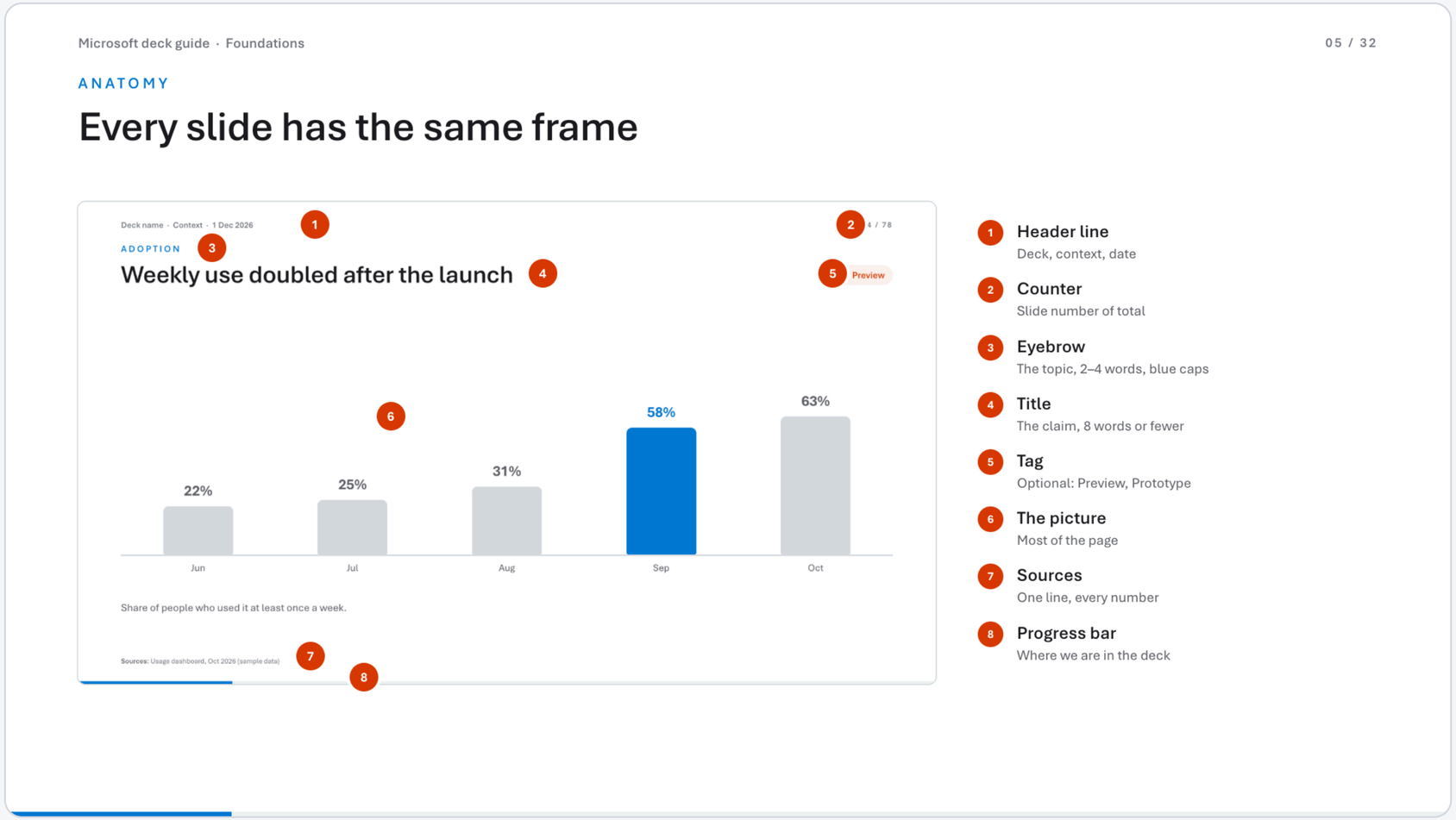
Pick the level for the deck, not for each slide: a simple deck can borrow one chart, a talk can use simple cards between drawings. All three share the same colours, type and frame, so they mix.



`cards`

Every slide makes one point

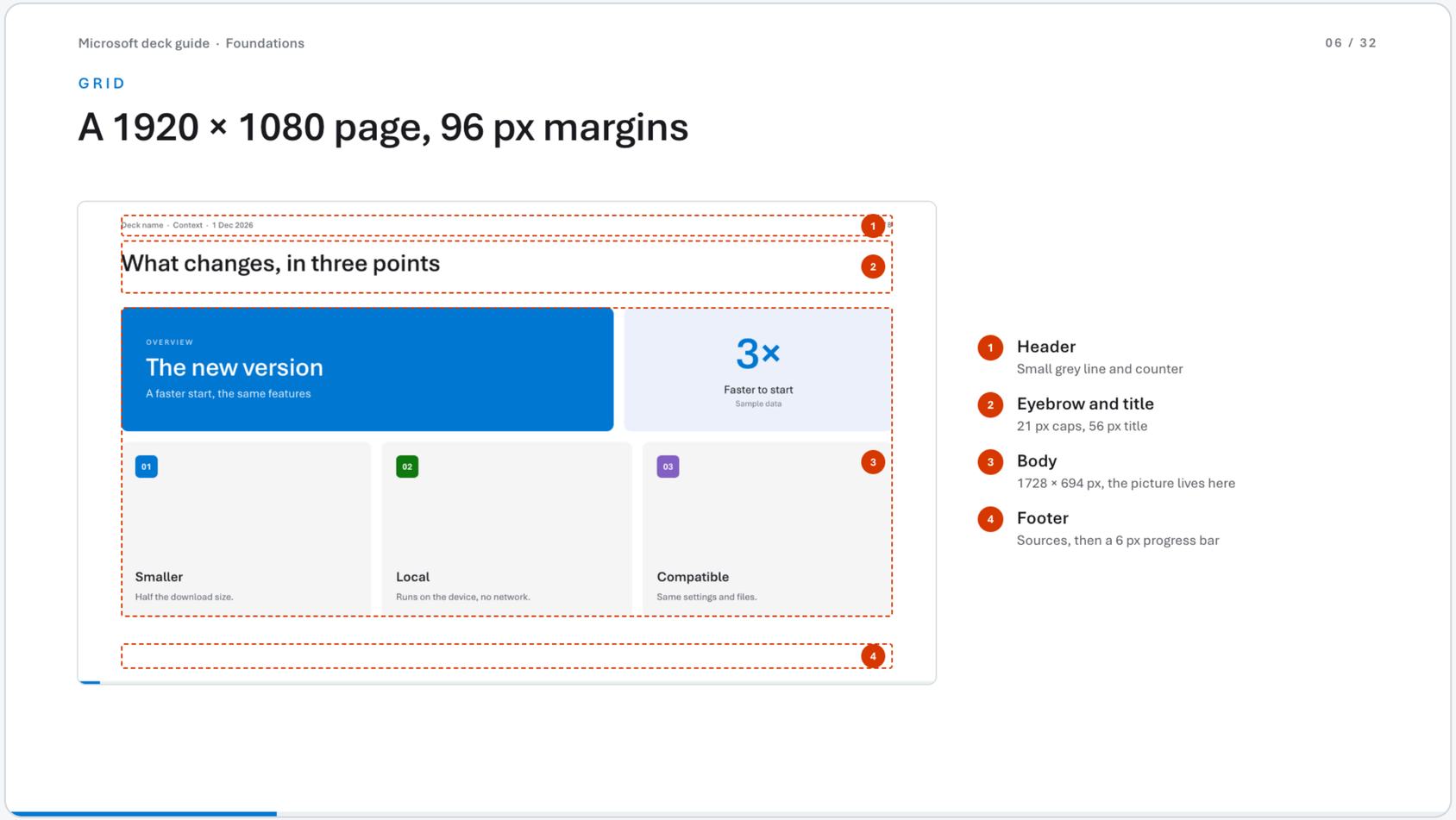
This page is itself a level-1 slide (the cards layout). The three habits apply at every level: a claim in the title, something that shows it, and a source under every number.



`guide-anatomy`

Every slide has the same frame

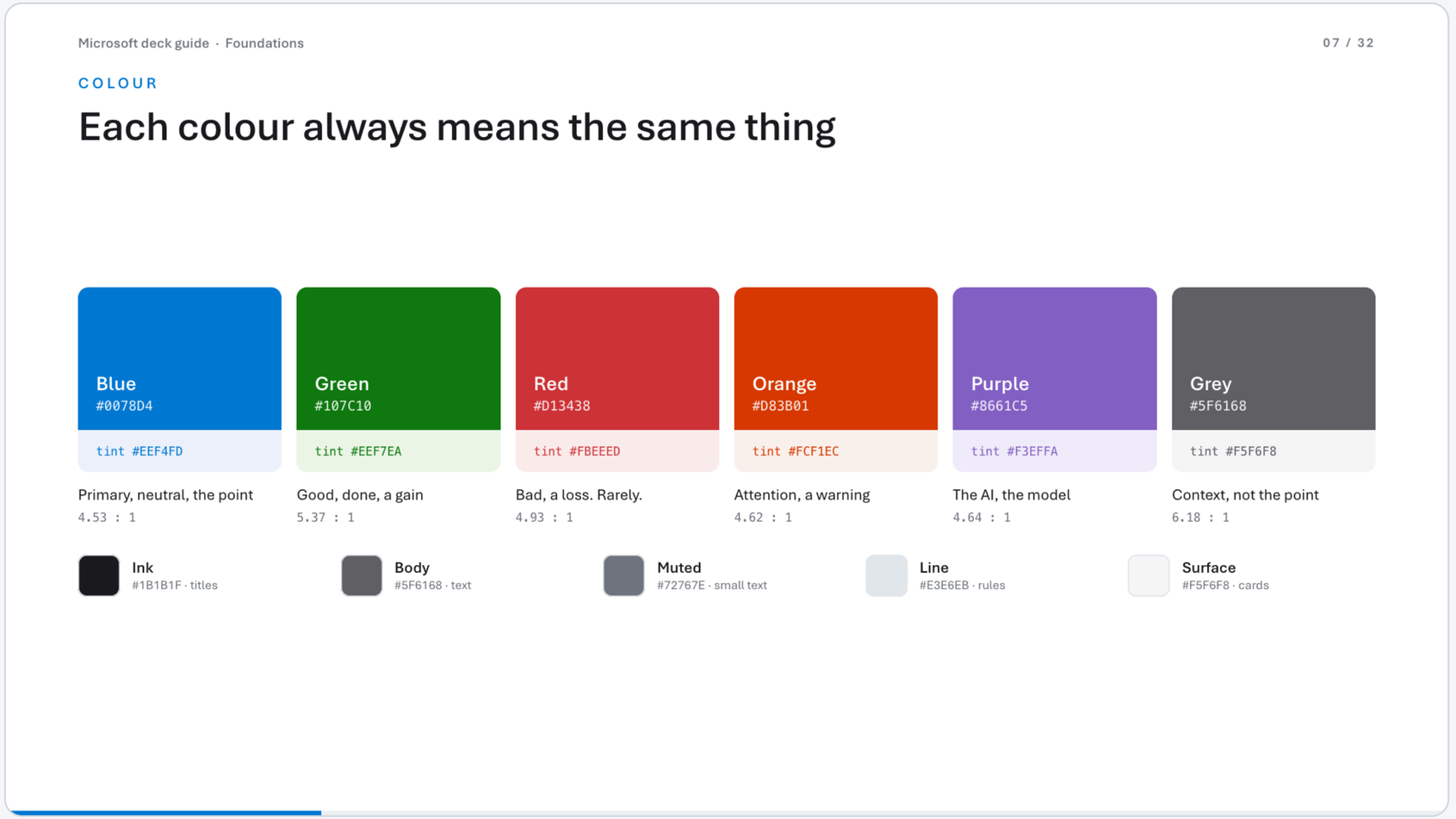
The build adds the header line, the counter, the sources line and the progress bar to every slide; covers and closing cards drop them. You write the eyebrow, the title and the body.



guide-anatomy

A 1920 × 1080 page, 96 px margins

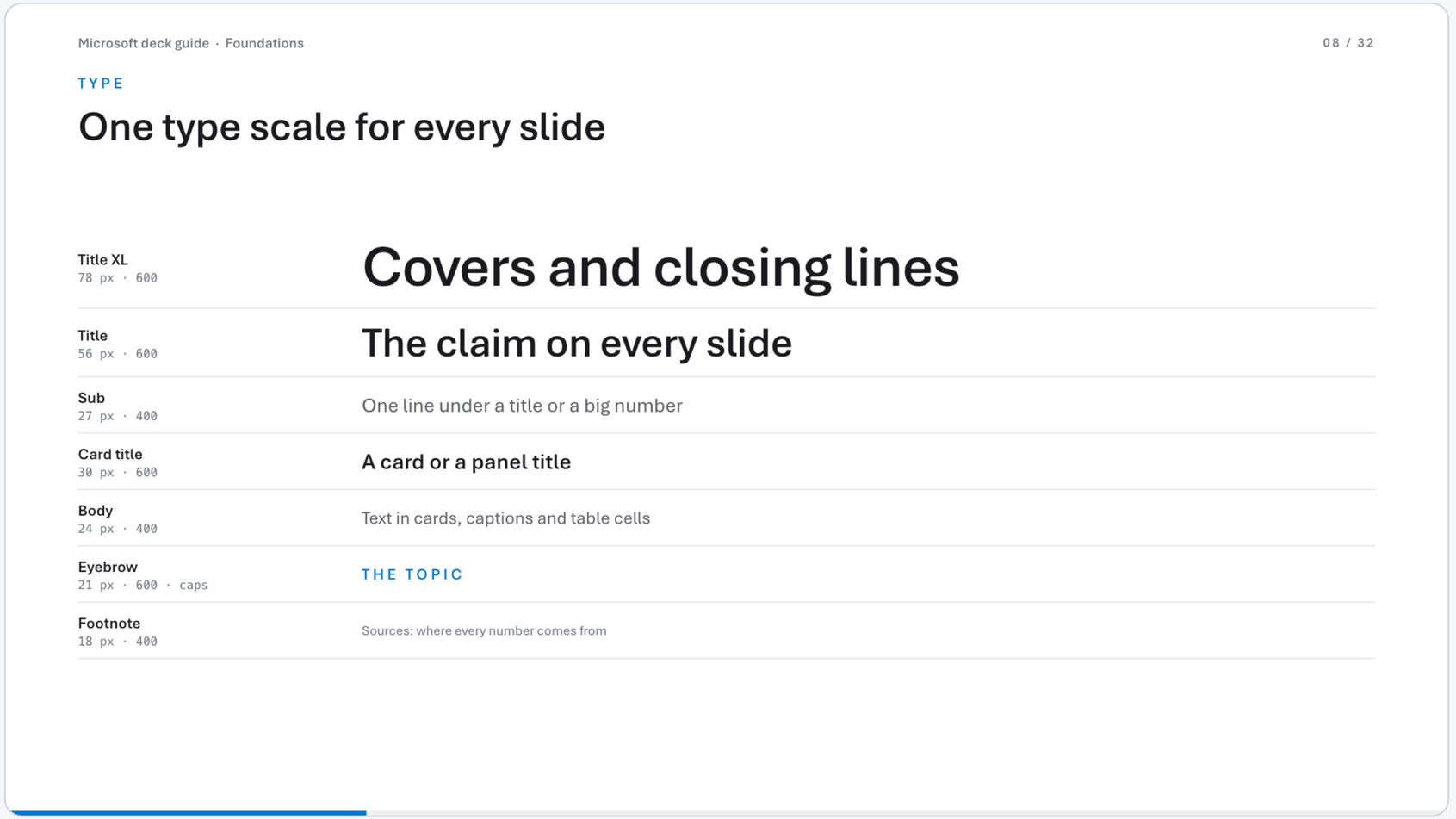
Slides are 16:9 at 1920 × 1080. Text never leaves the safe area (60–1860 × 24–1062); the build checks it. Corners are 14–22 px; lines 1.5–3 px; no blurred shadows anywhere.



`guide-swatches`

Each colour always means the same thing

The ratios are contrast on white; every text colour passes WCAG AA. Tints are for backgrounds, never for text. Pair colour with an icon or a word so the slide still reads in black and white.



`guide-typescale`

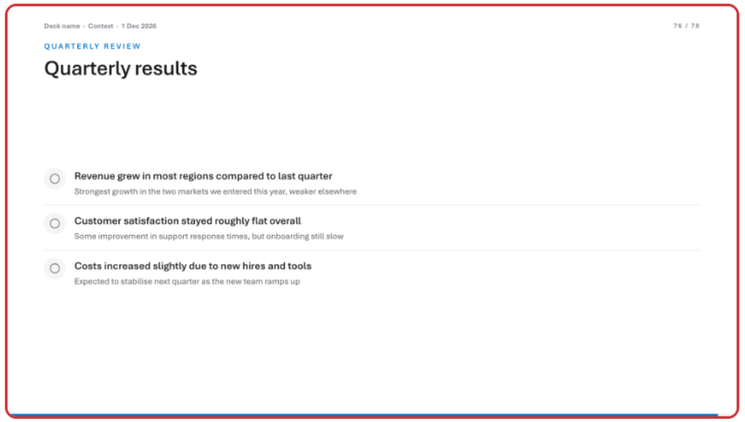
One type scale for every slide

Aptos when Microsoft Office is installed (embedded in the PDF), then Segoe UI, then Inter. Code in Menlo or Cascadia Mono. Numbers are tabular so columns line up.

DO AND DON'T

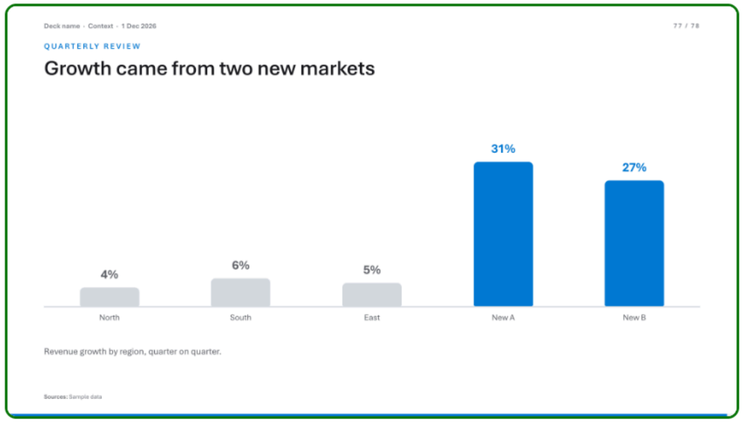
Say the point, then show it

Don't



A topic for a title, and a paragraph per bullet.

Do



The claim as the title, and a chart that proves it.

`guide-pair`

Say the point, then show it

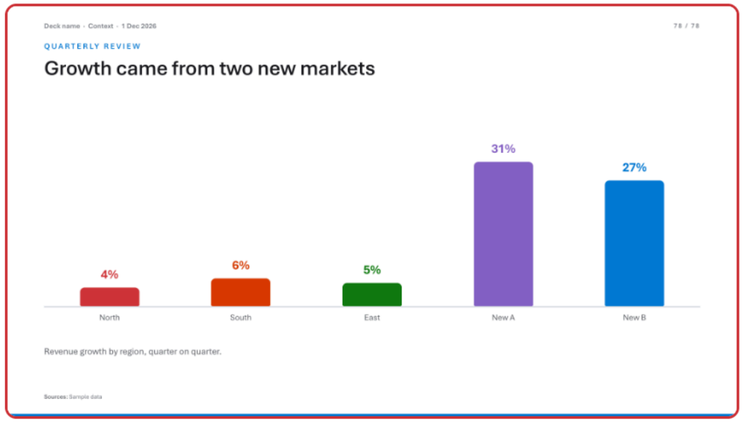
Same content twice. The left slide makes people read; the right one tells them what to think and shows why. Everything that was on the left goes into the speaker notes.

Microsoft deck guide · Foundations 10 / 32

DO AND DON'T

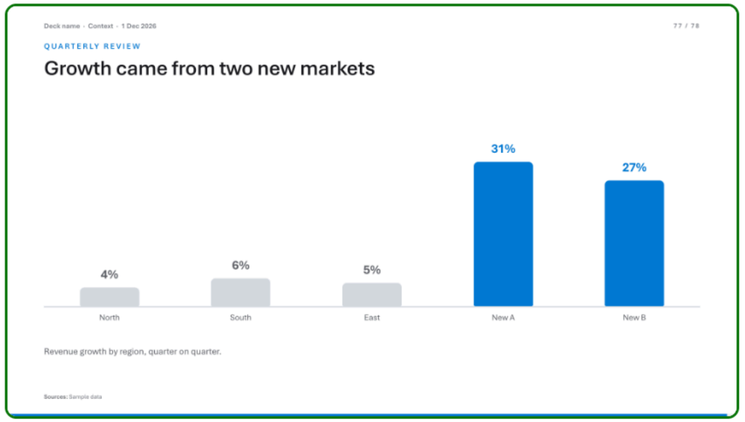
Colour marks what matters

Don't



A colour per bar: the eye has nowhere to go.

Do



Grey for context, blue for the point.

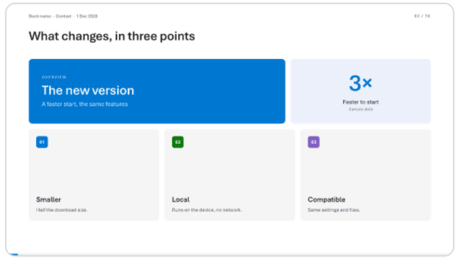
`guide-pair`

Colour marks what matters

Colour is a signal, not decoration. One tone for the point, grey for the rest, and green or red only when something is better or worse.

LEVEL 1 · SIMPLE

Cards and big numbers carry the point



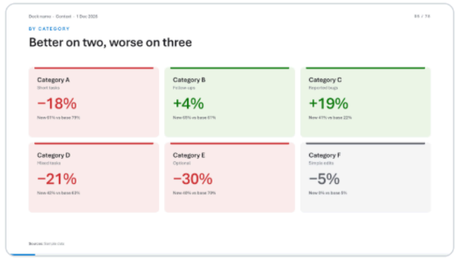
`cards` An overview in one page



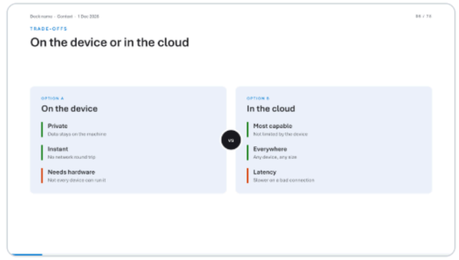
`scorecard` Two numbers, head to head



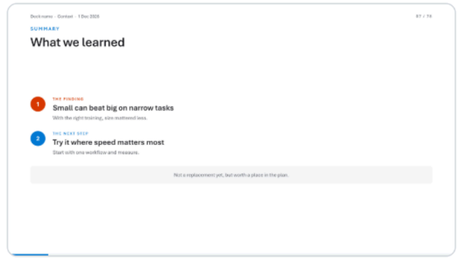
`bignumber` One number that is the point



`breakdown` A change per category



`versus` Two options, pros and costs

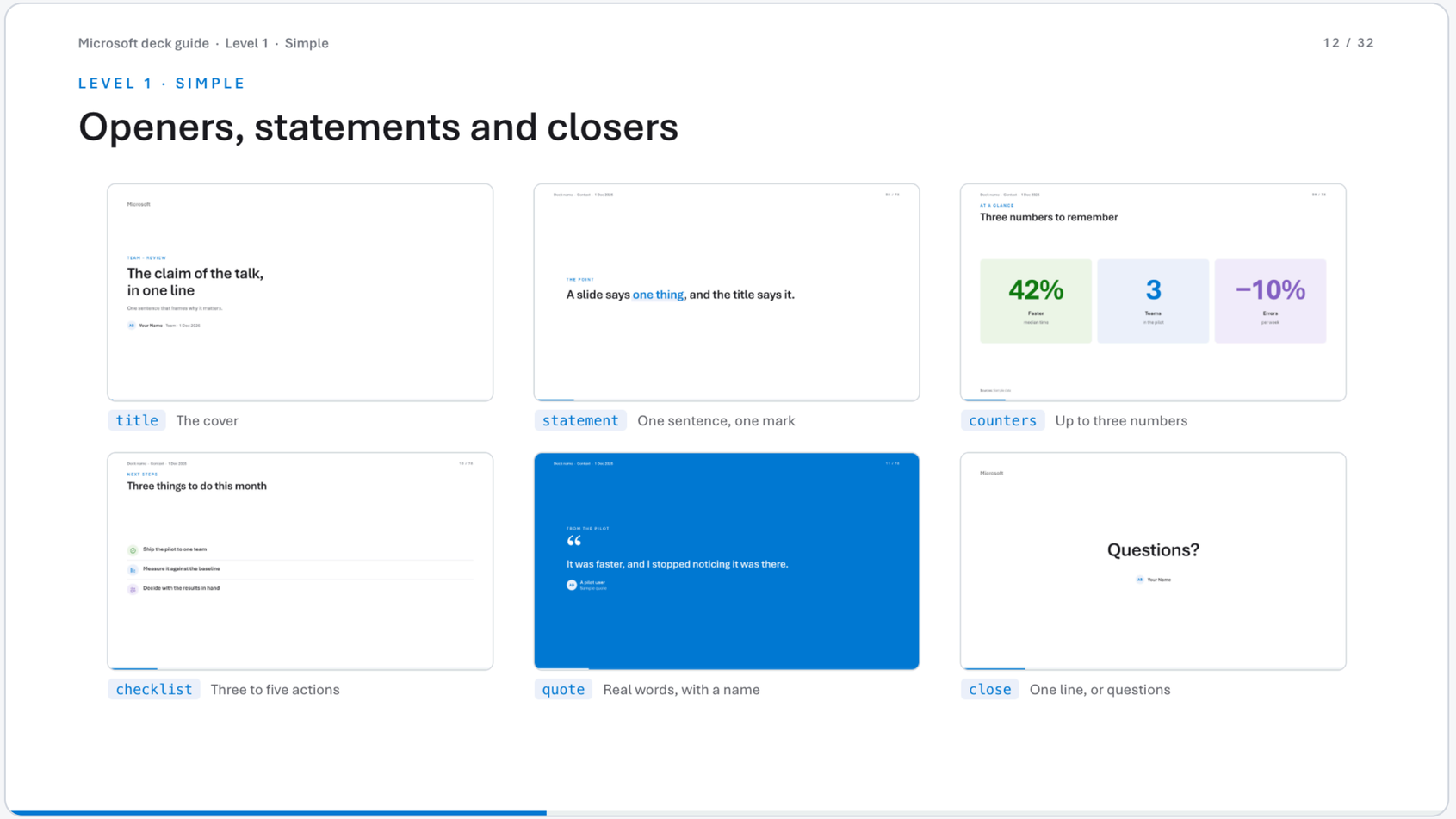


`takeaways` What to take away

`guide-catalog`

Cards and big numbers carry the point

Level 1 needs no drawing: tinted panels, big numbers in the meaning colours and short labels. These six layouts cover most updates and reviews.



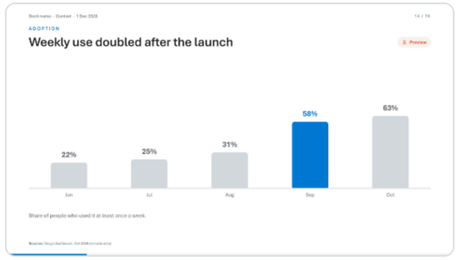
`guide-catalog`

Openers, statements and closers

Use a full-colour page (bg: blue or dark) once or twice per deck for rhythm, on a quote or a statement.

LEVEL 2 · GRAPHS

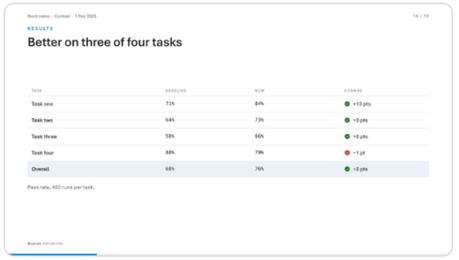
Charts and tables for numbers



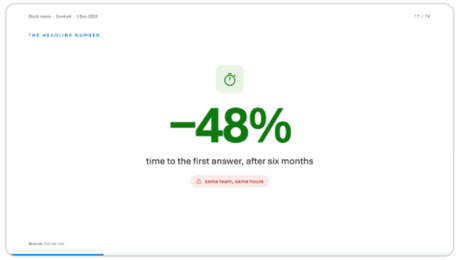
`bars` Compare values, one highlighted



`funnel` How a number narrows



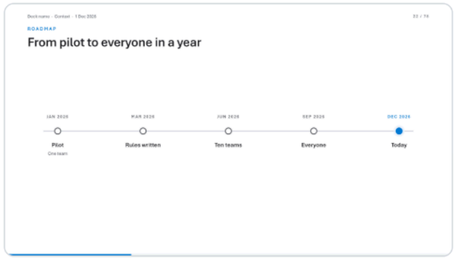
`matrix` A results table



`hero` One giant number



`split` Before and after



`timeline` Dates and today

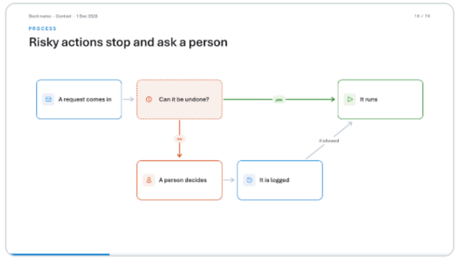
`guide-catalog`

Charts and tables for numbers

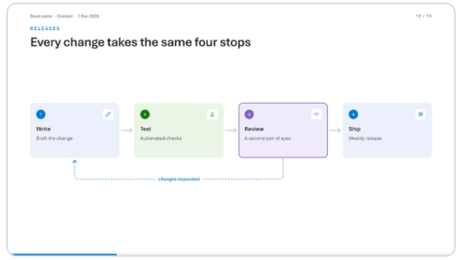
Level 2 adds charts and diagrams drawn from data. Label values directly, say the unit and the sample size, start bars at zero, and highlight the one the title talks about.

LEVEL 2 · GRAPHS

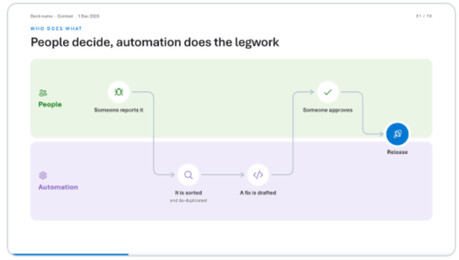
Diagrams for how things work



`flow` Steps with yes / no branches



`pipeline` Stages left to right



`lanes` Who does what



`cycle` A loop that repeats



`layers` A stack of parts

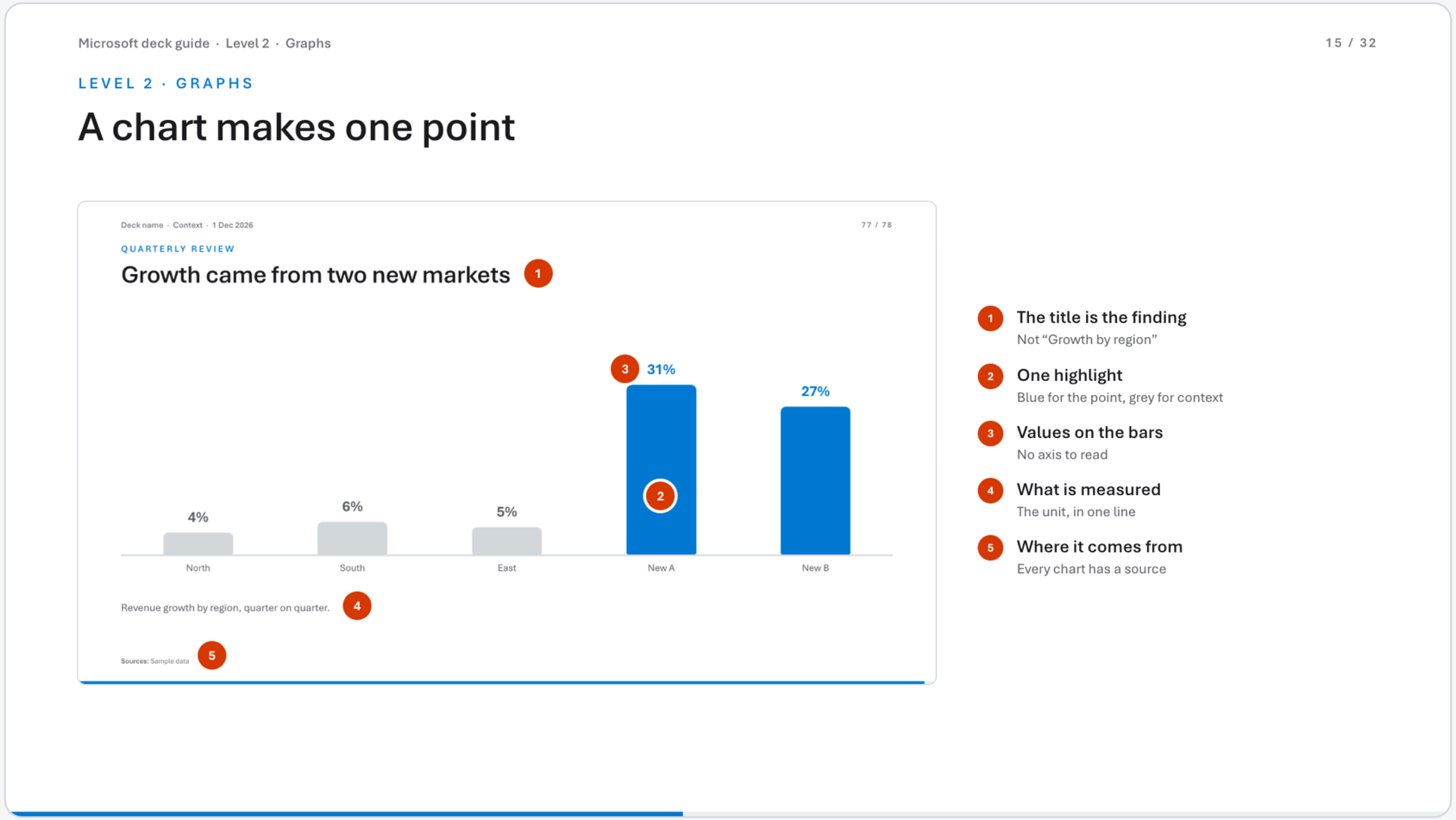


`quad` A 2 × 2 decision

`guide-catalog`

Diagrams for how things work

A diagram replaces a list when the order, the owner or the loop is the point. Boxes are things, lines are relationships, position means something.



guide-anatomy

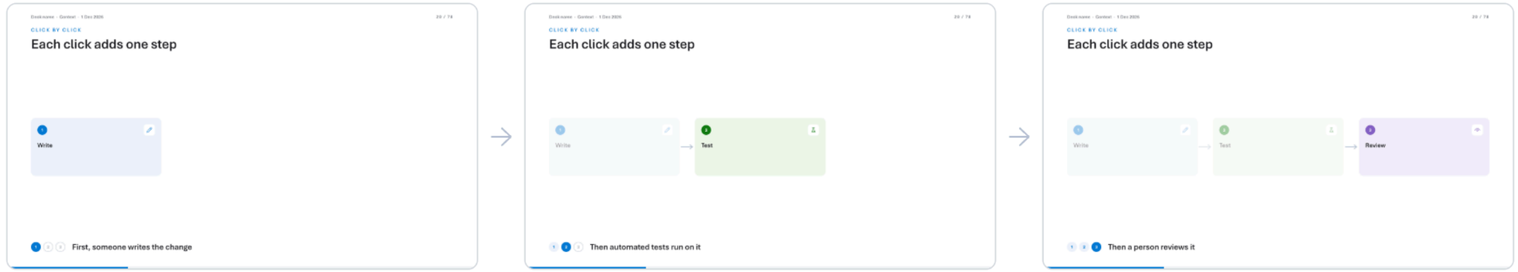
A chart makes one point

The same rules apply to tables: the baseline first, the change last, the overall row tinted, green and red only with a tick or a cross.

Microsoft deck guide · Level 2 · Graphs 16 / 32

LEVEL 2 · BUILDS

A click is the next page of the PDF



Click 1. One item, and a caption that says it.

Click 2. The new item is bright, the old one fades.

Click 3. Nothing moves; the caption changes.

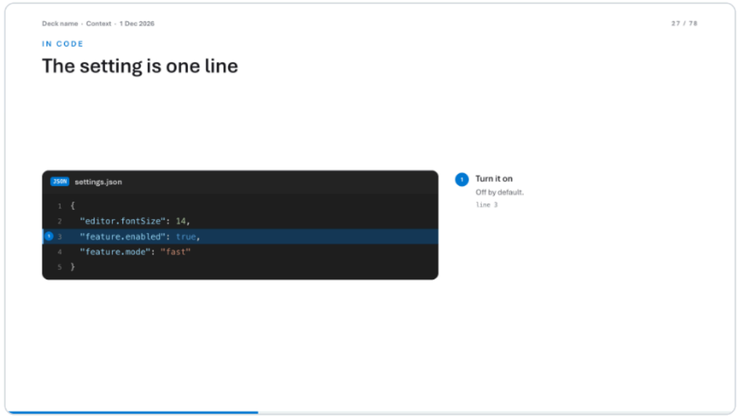
`guide-strip`

A click is the next page of the PDF

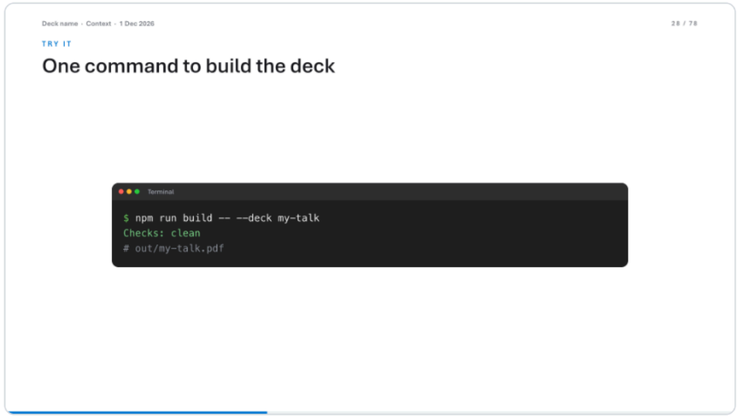
Add clicks: [{ caption, say }] to any list-like layout. There are no animations: each click is a real page, so the deck plays in any PDF viewer. If you cannot write the caption, you do not need the click.

LEVEL 2 · GRAPHS

Code and commands, with callouts



`code` Up to 12 lines, notes beside them



`terminal` Commands and their output

`guide-catalog`

Code and commands, with callouts

Code is 8 lines or fewer when you can, and the slide says in words what it does. Highlight the line that matters.

LEVEL 3 · ILLUSTRATIONS

A drawn object makes an idea stick

1

ONE OBJECT

Pick an everyday thing that is the idea

A gate, a key, a road sign. If the names could be swapped for any topic, pick another.

2

DRAWN IN CODE

Draw a new picture for every deck

The designs here show the style. Invent your own object for your idea.

3

SAME LOOK

Same colours, lines and type as levels 1 and 2

So drawings sit next to cards and charts.

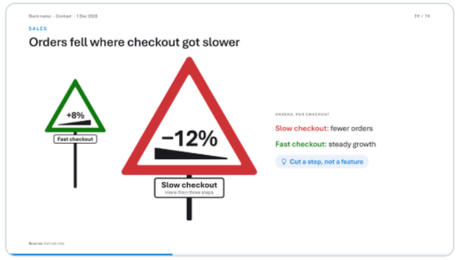
takeaways

A drawn object makes an idea stick

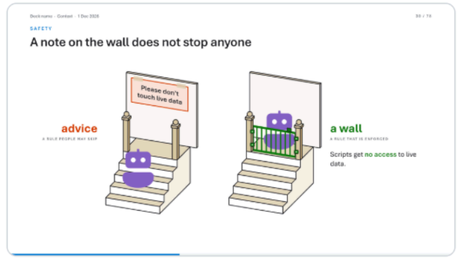
Save level 3 for talks people should remember. docs/designs.md shows how to write a new design.

LEVEL 3 · ILLUSTRATIONS

One object per idea



`roadsign` A change, as a warning sign



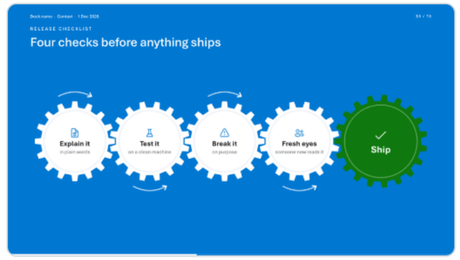
`gate` Advice versus a real barrier



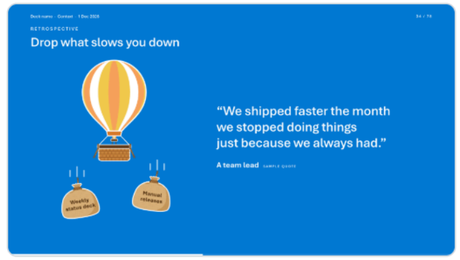
`metro` A decision as a metro map



`keyring` Levels of access as keys



`gears` Checks that must all turn



`balloon` What to drop to go faster

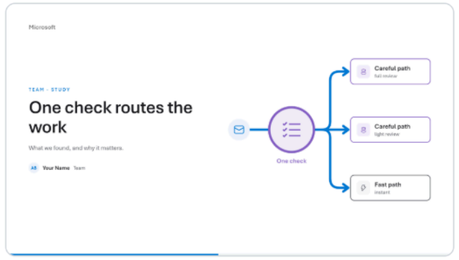
`guide-catalog`

One object per idea

Six of the designs in designs/. Each takes plain fields (a label, a few lines, a tone) and draws the object around them.

LEVEL 3 · HOUSE STYLE

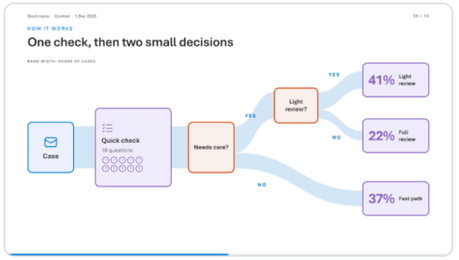
The six slides people pick



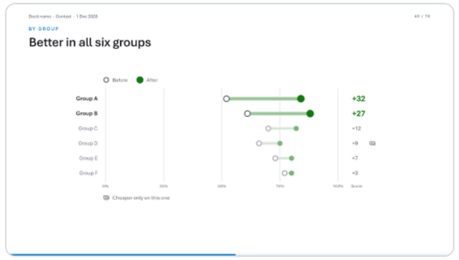
`fork-cover` The idea, drawn on the cover



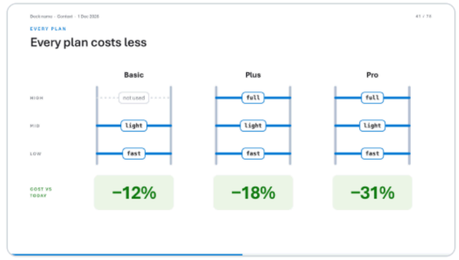
`sieve` Numbers you can count



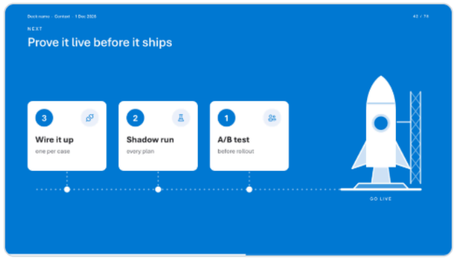
`flow-bands` A flow sized by share



`dumbbell` The few that matter, bold



`ladders` One object, giant results



`launch` A drawn close

`guide-catalog`

The six slides people pick

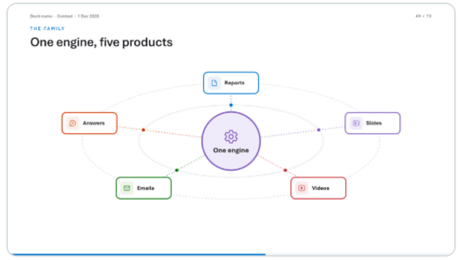
When three versions of the same deck were compared side by side, these six slides won. They share one drawing style and very few words. examples/front-desk.mjs uses all six in order; start there for an illustrated deck.

LEVEL 3 · MORE ILLUSTRATIONS

Machines for how it works



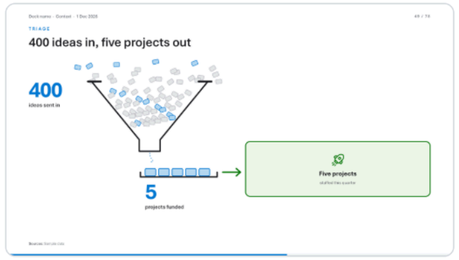
`factory` Steps as machines on a belt



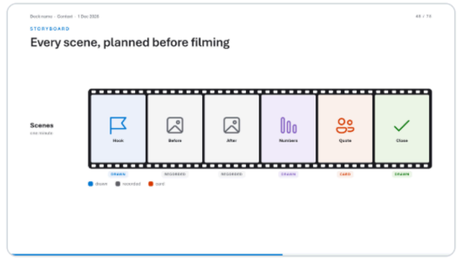
`orbit` One engine, many products



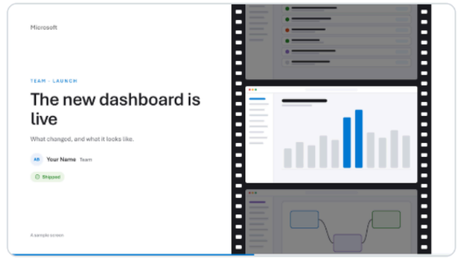
`devices` What goes in, what comes out



`hopper` Many in, a few out



`film-strip` Scenes, pictures or drawn cells



`picture-cover` A cover with a real picture

`guide-catalog`

Machines for how it works

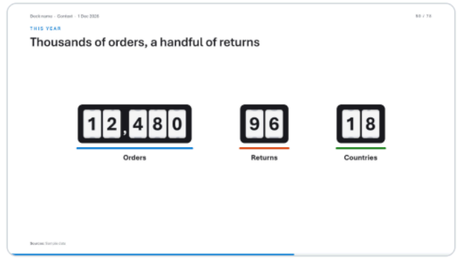
From designs/illustrations.mjs. Use them when the slide explains a process or a product: the factory builds one machine per click, film-strip and picture-cover take real stills (from an animated webp, extract full frames with magick file.webp -coalesce frame-%03d.png).

LEVEL 3 · MORE ILLUSTRATIONS

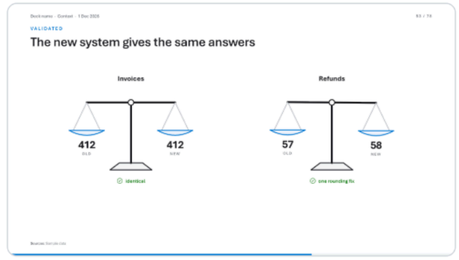
Objects for counting and comparing



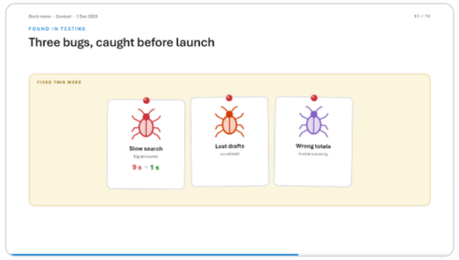
`stopwatch` Time, split into parts



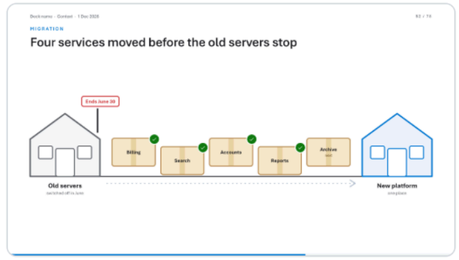
`odometer` Big running totals



`scales` Two values that should match



`pinboard` Bugs found, and what changed



`moving` A migration against a deadline

`guide-catalog`

Objects for counting and comparing

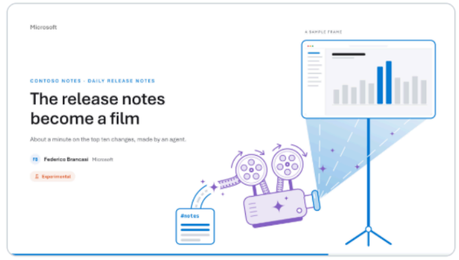
Each object carries one number story: a stopwatch for speed, an odometer for volume, scales for parity, a pinboard for problems found, a moving van for a migration. Keep labels to a word or two; the object does the talking.

LEVEL 3 · GALLERY

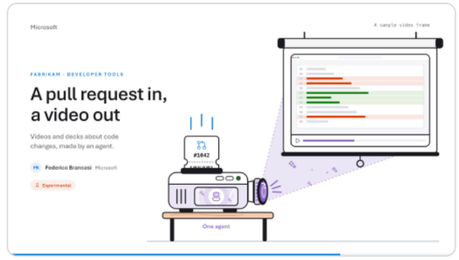
Three decks, three worlds



`new-terminal` A port: boxes you can count



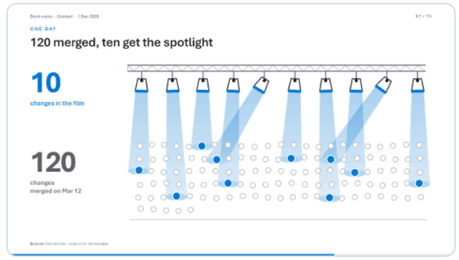
`daily-film` A cinema: a page becomes film



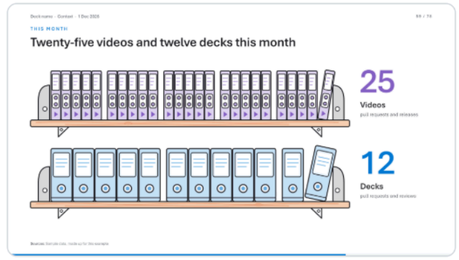
`pr-videos` A studio: the agent inside the projector



`the same world` A lighthouse finds the hazards



`the same world` Spotlights pick ten of many



`the same world` Shelves you count in fives

`guide-catalog`

Three decks, three worlds

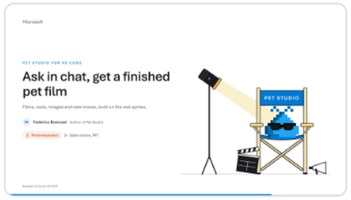
Each illustrated example lives in one world chosen from its topic, with one object that comes back on every slide. They show the bar, not a template: a new deck picks its own world and draws its own pictures. docs/illustrating.md explains the method.

LEVEL 3 · GALLERY

Four more worlds, drawn in detail



`tasting-pass` A kitchen



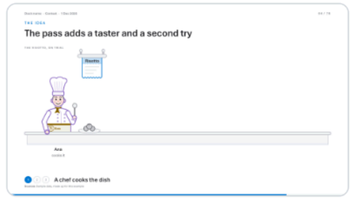
`pet-studio-example` A film set



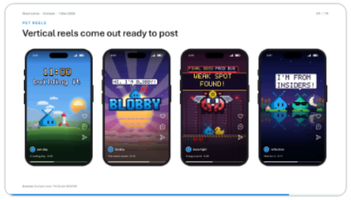
`code-walkthroughs-example` A press



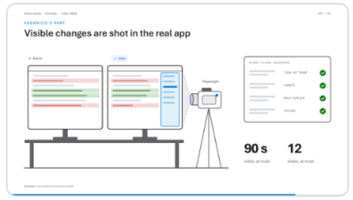
`first-order` A bakery



`kitchen` One chef, every pose



`film set` Reels on iPhones



`press` Filmed in the app



`bakery` A door that closes

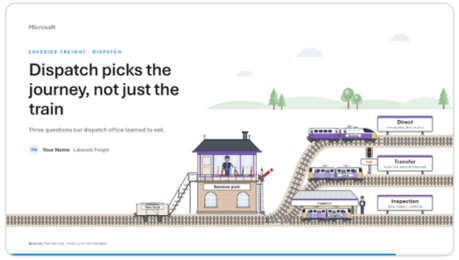
`guide-catalog`

Four more worlds, drawn in detail

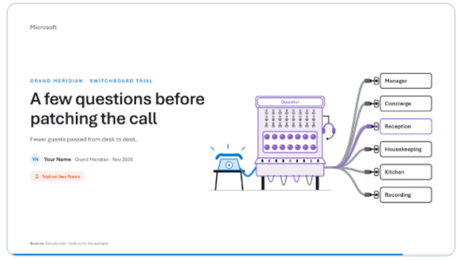
These four were made by agents that knew only this kit and its skill, then refined from one round of feedback: the characters and devices drawn in full detail (docs/illustrating.md, The detail bar). Two are real projects with public sources (the pet and the code walkthroughs); in the other two every name and number is made up.

LEVEL 3 · GALLERY

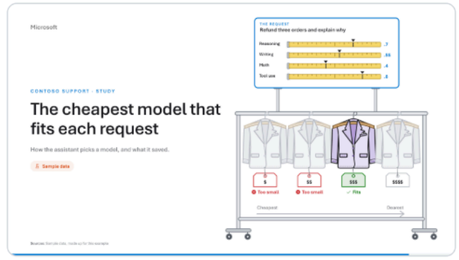
Six more worlds



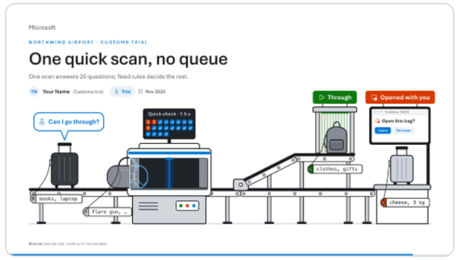
`freight-line` A railway



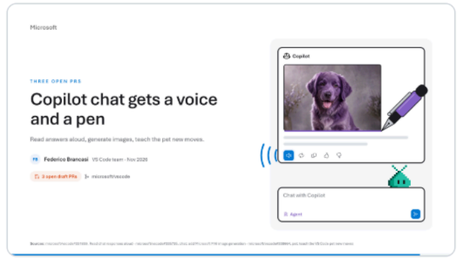
`switchboard` A switchboard



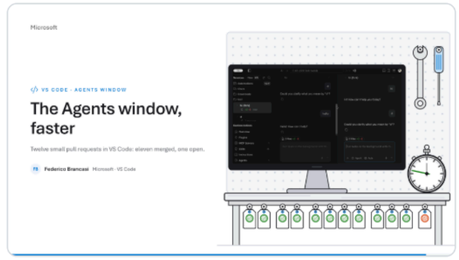
`fitting-room` A tailor's rack



`green-channel` A customs hall



`chat-media` A voice and a pen



`agents-speed` A workbench

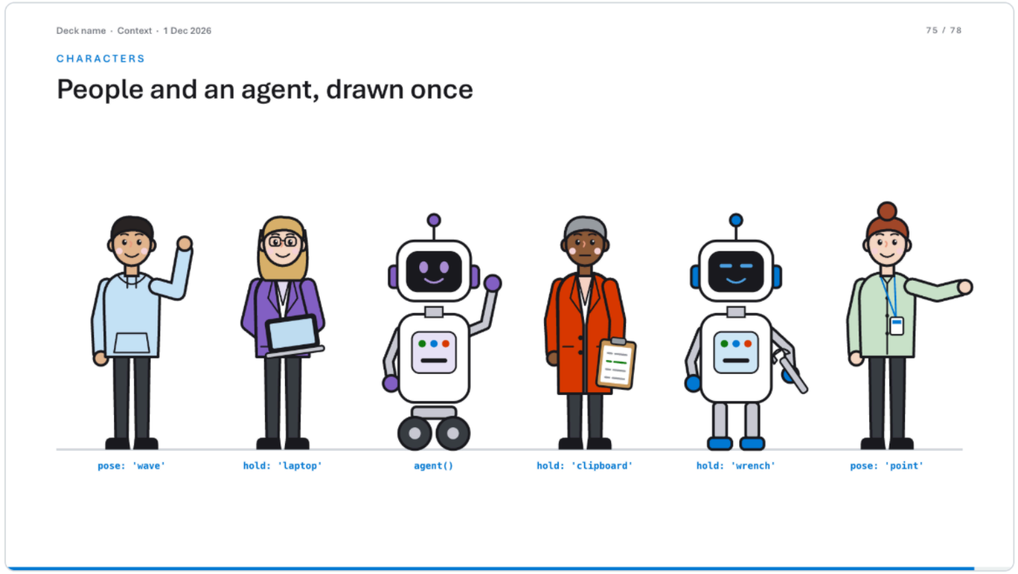
`guide-catalog`

Six more worlds

Six more decks, each in its own world. Two are real work with public sources (chat-media and agents-speed); in the others every name and number is made up. The gallery website shows every page of every deck.

LEVEL 3 · CHARACTERS

People and an agent, drawn once



`src/characters.mjs` person() and agent(): poses, outfits and what they hold

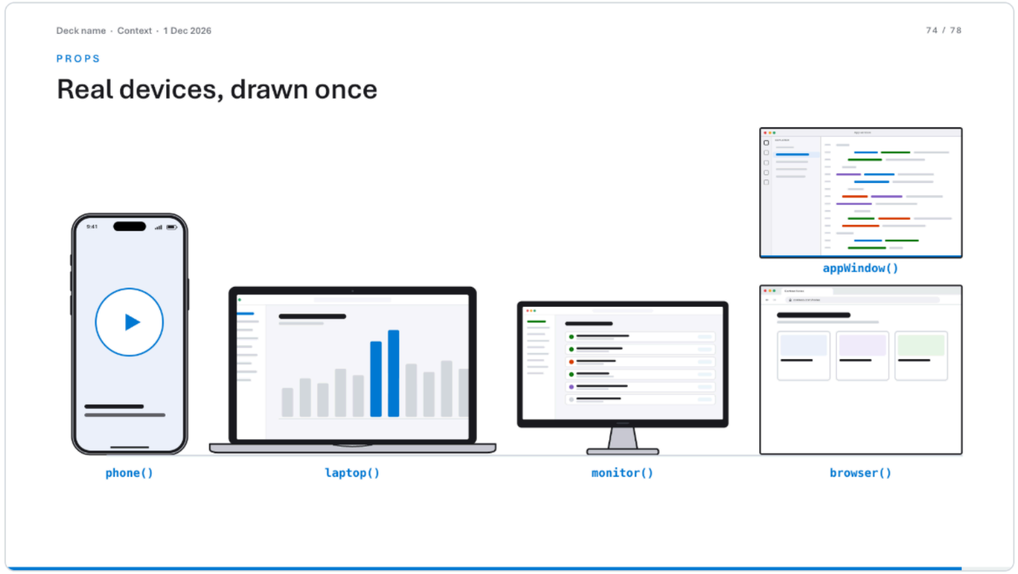
`guide-catalog`

People and an agent, drawn once

Characters for any deck: a person with a face, hair, clothes and hands, in six poses, holding a laptop, a clipboard, a phone, a mug, a wrench, a flag or a magnifier; and the agent, a friendly robot in the AI's purple. docs/designs.md, Characters.

LEVEL 3 · PROPS

Devices and windows, drawn once

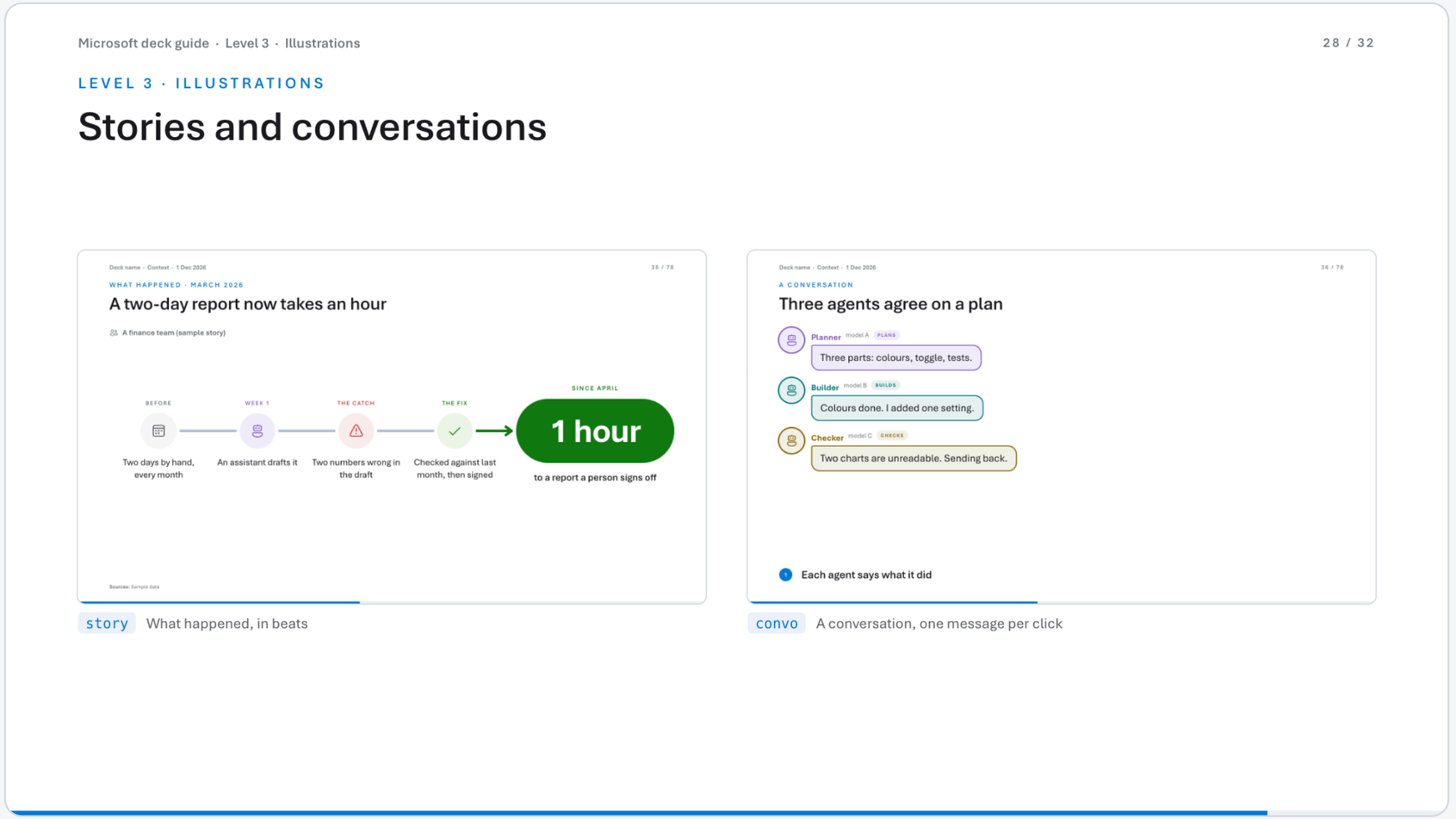


`src/props.mjs` phone, laptop, monitor, appWindow, browser: frames that hold a real screen

`guide-catalog`

Devices and windows, drawn once

Props are detailed frames for the devices and windows illustrated decks keep needing. They hold a real screenshot or your own HTML and draw the device around it with true proportions, so you can spend your drawing time on the idea. docs/designs.md, Props.



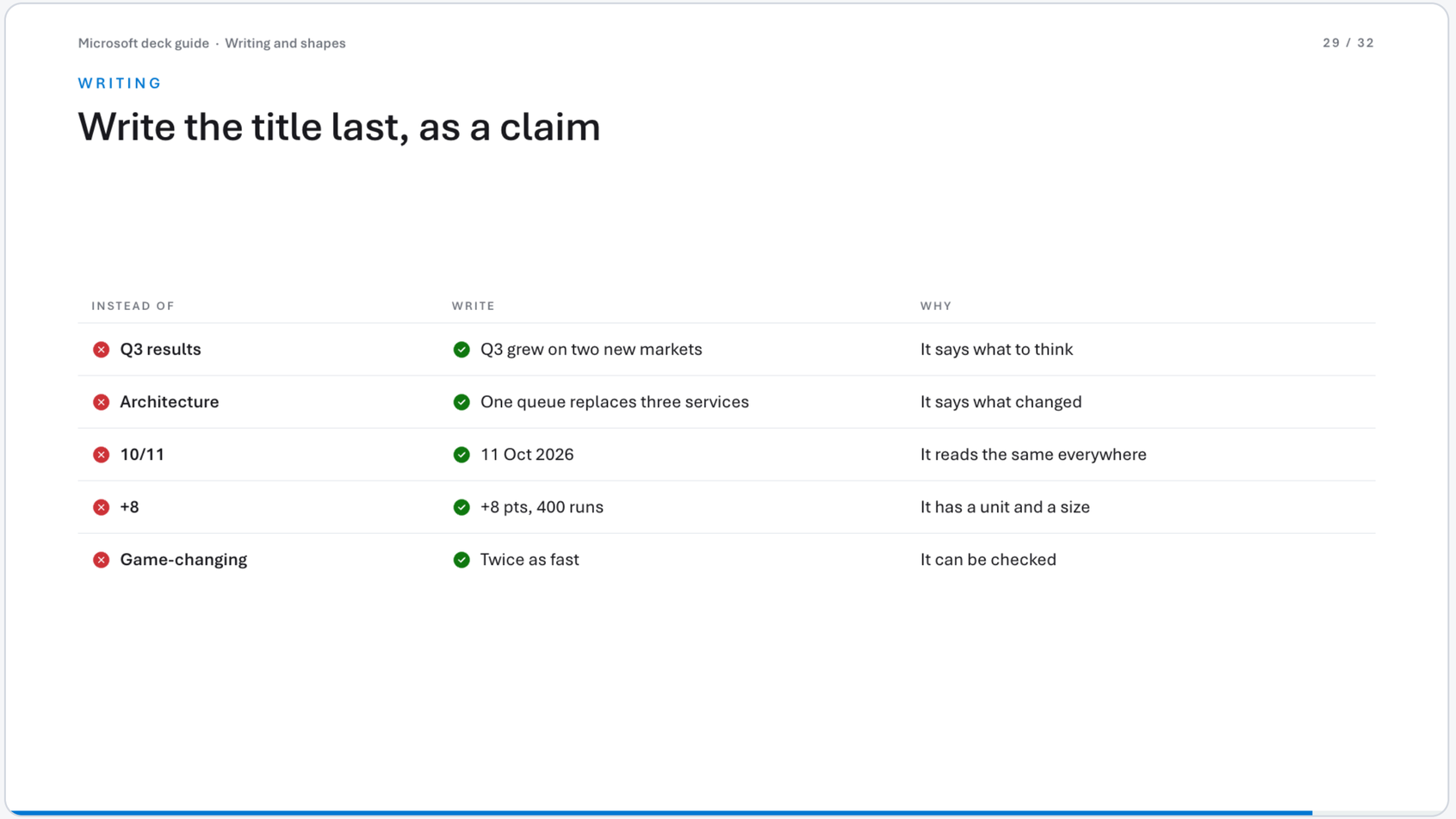
`story` What happened, in beats

`convo` A conversation, one message per click

`guide-catalog`

Stories and conversations

A story comes right before the point it supports: when, who, what happened, the outcome. A conversation builds one message per click and keeps every word as it was said.



`matrix`

Write the title last, as a claim

Sentence case, no full stop, 8 words or fewer. Plain words, no hype, no emoji. Quotes word for word, with a name.

DECK SHAPES

Three outlines, one per level

An update
Level 1 · 5–8 slides



A report
Level 2 · 8–14 slides



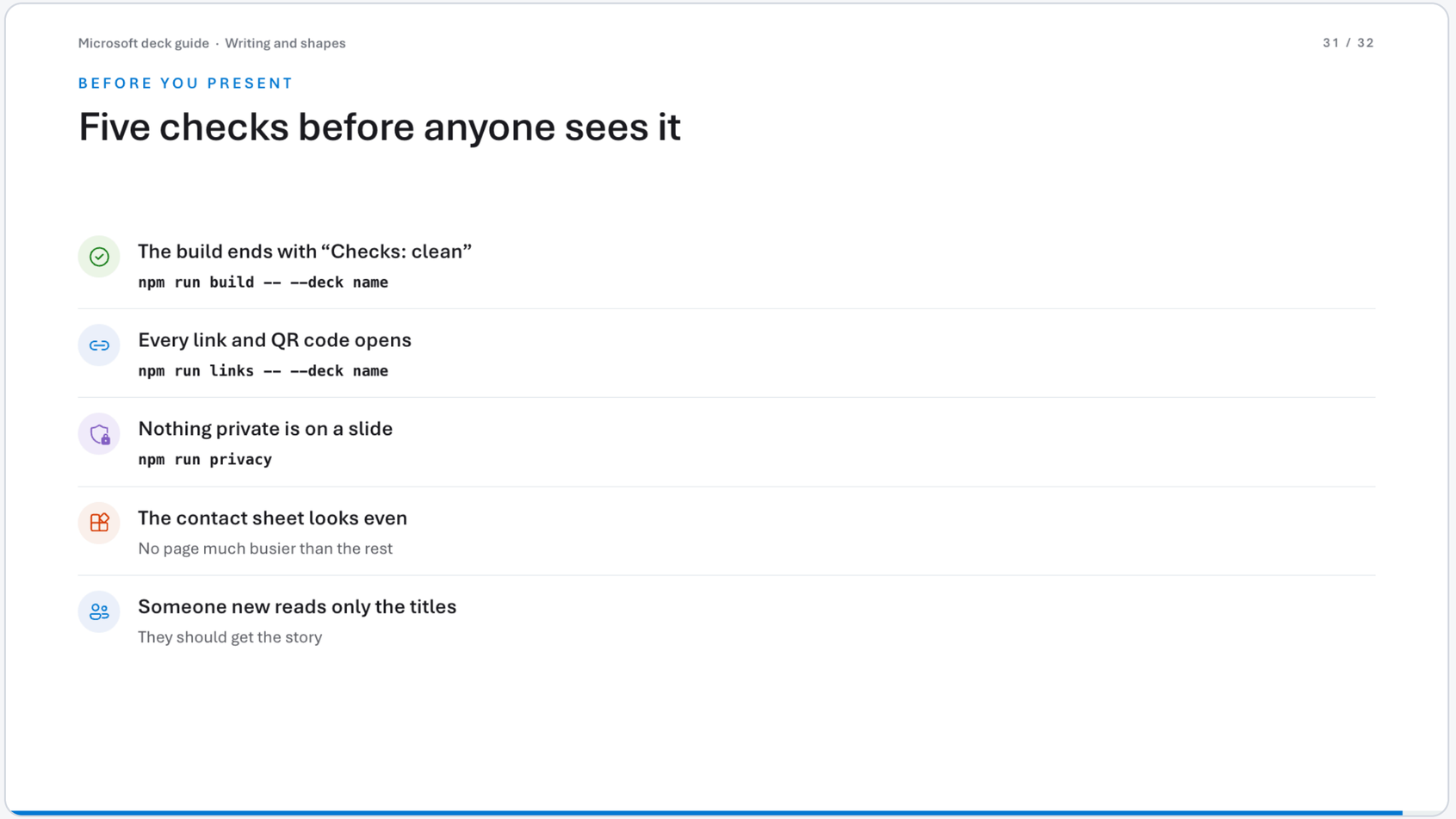
A talk
Level 3 · 6–12 slides



`guide-strip`

Three outlines, one per level

Start with the finding, not the method. Show one real example before an average. End on what to do. The examples/ folder has a full deck for each shape.



`checklist`

Five checks before anyone sees it

The build checks overflow, overlap, the safe area, word counts, sources, notes, contrast and blurred shadows. The last check is a person: if the titles alone tell the story, the deck works.



`close`

One point per slide. Show it, and source it.

The end.